

PRAYER SERVICE Sailors often attended religious services before and after battle. Here British officers and men pray for their fallen comrades after the battle of the Nile (1798).



ORTHODOX CHAPEL Many ships had their own chapels, where a chaplain could perform services and rites. This Orthodox chapel from the Greek WWII-era battleship *Georgius Averof* came with its own icons.

> *May the great God . . . grant to my country and . . . Europe in general, a great and glorious victory: and may no misconduct, in anyone, tarnish it . . .*
>
> **HORATIO NELSON** Prayer written before battle of Trafalgar on October 21, 1805

RELIGION ON BOARD

Clergymen, monks, or nuns on board were traditionally regarded as unlucky. In the 16th century Spanish royal galleys, which operated close to shore and were never at sea for long periods, had clergy assigned to them, but the oceangoing sailing fleet did not. The celebration of mass on board was banned because the consecrated wafer or wine might be spilled in the sea. The ship's master led services on board and the ship's boys sang the Ave Maria at sunset. Spanish sailors wore medallions of the saints and Virgin around their necks as charms, and made ex-voto offerings in churches to give thanks for a safe voyage. English sailors of Francis Drake's time, affected by Protestantism, would sing hymns on deck, while denouncing their Catholic enemies as merely superstitious. Religious services on board Royal Navy ships in the 18th century were mostly conducted by the captain. The growth of Christian evangelicalism in the early 19th century affected Royal Navy officers, who were more likely to take their religious duties seriously. From 1812 the official policy of the Royal Navy was that every ship from a sixth-rate upward should have a chaplain, but until the mid-19th century there were never enough chaplains to fulfill this aspiration. Eventually, in the course of the 19th century, religious personnel on board were generally provided by navies around the world as part of a concept of a well-run ship caring for its sailors.

BLESSING CEREMONY Clergy inspect a submarine after a ceremony. Another maritime tradition views a priest on board as bad luck.



ORGAN Specially built organs for submarines, such as this WWII model, were issued for religious services until the 1980s.

